STATIC

A short film screenplay

A quiet examination of grief in the aftermath of a classmate's suicide.

FADE IN:

INT. HIGH SCHOOL HALLWAY - MORNING

Lockers line both sides of a narrow corridor. Fluorescent lights buzz faintly overhead. A wooden table sits against the wall near the main office. On it: a framed school photograph of BEN (17), surrounded by white lilies and small handwritten notes on colored cards. JONAH (17) stands two paces back, his backpack slung over one shoulder. Students walk past the table. Some stop briefly, lower their heads, then move on. Others avoid looking altogether. Jonah does not move. He stares at the photograph. The frame is slightly crooked.

INT. CLASSROOM - LATER

Desks arranged in rows. A TEACHER speaks at the front of the room, her voice muted and distant under the room's atmosphere. Beside Jonah, an empty desk sits untouched. Jonah looks down at his notebook. On the wooden surface of the desk, carved into the varnish years ago, are small scratched initials: "J + B". He traces his index finger along the groove of the letter B.

EXT. SCHOOL OVAL - AFTERNOON

Grey overcast sky. The wind blows dry leaves across the grass track. Jonah sits alone on the bottom tier of the metal bleachers. Down on the field, a physical education class runs laps. Their shouts and footsteps carry softly across the open ground. Jonah pulls his knees up, resting his arms on them. He takes his phone out of his pocket.

ON SCREEN: An unread messaging thread with Ben from two weeks ago. The last message sent by Ben reads simply: "You around this weekend?" Below it, Jonah's reply: "Busy with work stuff, catch you Monday." Jonah stares at the small screen for a long time. The screen dims, going black. He rolls the phone over in his hand, feeling its cold plastic casing, before slipping it deep into his coat pocket.

EXT. BUS STOP - DUSK

The streetlights click on one by one along the avenue. Jonah sits under the glass shelter. Rain begins to drop lightly against the metal roof. A GIRL from his year sits two meters away on the same bench. She looks at the rain, then glances at Jonah.

GIRL

(softly)

You were friends with him, right?

Jonah looks up slowly. He pauses for a beat.

JONAH

Yeah. I was.

She nods quietly, looking back out at the street. Neither of them speaks again. The bus rolls up to the curb, its air brakes releasing with a heavy hiss. Jonah gets up and steps aboard into the yellow interior light.

THE END

FADE OUT.